

30 years. It is probably not the world we will live in for the next 30 years. In any case, your authors judge it too risky now. (More in Chapter 5.)

Even if the currency and the bond markets were safe, however, you'd still have to reckon with a very long period before you could compound real after-tax gains from bonds into serious money.

SO HOW DO YOU GET REAL FAMILY MONEY?

“Behind every great fortune there is a crime,” said Balzac. He was mostly right. The great fortunes of the pre-Industrial Revolution period, especially those in France, often resulted from some kind of ancient larceny. There was no other way. Capitalism in its modern form had yet to be invented. Land or special monopoly privileges granted by the king were the basis of most great wealth. The former was usually the result of a crime of some sort; the latter was a crime itself.

Land could be taken by force. In fact, that's how most of Europe's nobility got it. The Germanic tribes that overran France in the second to fifth centuries did not stop to check with the local office of deed registry. They took the land they wanted. Those who took it and held it were men of arms—strongmen—who then attached the names of the places they had stolen to their own names. Charles de Tancarville. Charles d'Argenton. Charles de Gaulle. In the nineteenth century, it was relatively common for people to add a “de” to their family names to make themselves a bit more distinguished.

Settled on their *terres*, the rough warlords of the early Middle Ages built castles to defend their lands and took on all the pretensions and *droits de seigneurs* of a permanent aristocracy. They were even excused from paying taxes.

If you wanted a family fortune back then, your best bet was to take it, as the ancestors of the Queen Elizabeth II of England or those of Prince Albert of Monaco did. The queen's remote ancestor, William the Conqueror, got his name by taking over England. Its lands were distributed to his soldiers,